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INSIDE THE WAR ON **HARVARD**

THE POWER DYNAMIC, BLURRED

With billions at stake, Trump's offensive against elite schools tests two accomplished academics whose careers were long bound together

DR. ALAN GARBER

Current position: Harvard president
Degrees: PhD in economics from Harvard and an MD from Stanford



DR. JAY BHATTACHARYA

Current position: director of the National Institutes of Health
Degrees: PhD in economics and an MD from Stanford

By Ilya Marritz

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

In early May, Harvard president Dr. Alan Garber received a letter from the National Institutes of Health notifying him that hundreds of scientific grants had been rescinded, as the next step in the escalating battle between Harvard and the Trump administration. In an instant, the years-long collective efforts of countless researchers to cure illness, protect against disease, and improve human knowledge were thrown into disarray.

Still, the letter did offer Garber one ray of hope: He could appeal the decision to the director of the NIH, Dr. Jay Bhattacharya. It was a name Garber knew exceptionally well. For more than three decades, Garber had nurtured Bhattacharya's career, first as his undergraduate honors thesis adviser, and later as a colleague and peer. Now their relationship had entered dramatically new territory. As the letter made clear, Garber could go to his former student as a supplicant and plead with him to reconsider.

The May 6 letter is but one document in a fast-growing body of hostile communications from Washington. Yet it points to something significant: Two of the front-line adversaries are bound by deep social ties and a shared academic interest in the money side of medicine. Garber and Bhattacharya have coauthored nearly a dozen academic papers and chap-

HARVARD, Page A14

A potent medical tool, blunted by RFK Jr.'s hostility

Hailed within life sciences, mRNA now faces political headwinds, chilly reception

By Jonathan Saltzman

GLOBE STAFF

Dr. Jonathan Kagan had his sights set on next year, when the Harvard scientist planned to start clinical trials on an experimental cancer treatment based on the same technology

— messenger RNA — that underpinned COVID-19 vaccines.

Then on Aug. 5, Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. announced that the federal government would no longer fund work on that type of vaccine, not only rocking vaccine

makers such as Cambridge-based Moderna but also a host of biotechs developing mRNA treatments for cancers, cystic fibrosis, and rare diseases.

Already, Kagan said, the Trump administration's antipathy toward mRNA is chilling investment that his Watertown biotech, Corner Therapeutics, needs to bring its treatment for cervical cancer to clinical trials.

As recently as Wednesday, he said, a venture capital firm told Corner that it would not participate in the start-up's second round of fund-raising because of the political climate. Kagan hopes such wariness doesn't force a delay in the trial.

"Investors are saying, 'We're not in the business of investing in mRNA technologies because the White

MESSANGER RNA, Page A15



Senator Mitch McConnell with his wife, Elaine Chao, at the Fancy Farm picnic.

McCONNELL, Page A12

Out fit

Sunday: Hot, storms later.
High: 89-93. Low: 61-66.
Monday: Sunny, less humid.
High: 69-74. Low: 56-61.
Sunrise: 5:54 Sunset: 7:42
Complete report, **A22**.
Deaths, **A16-21**.

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\$6.00

Breathtaking celestial photographs, most recently from the Vera C. Rubin Observatory camera (below), capture a beauty beyond terrestrial concerns. N1.



Tourism's front-line workers do more than give directions, as visits to the visitor center show. N11.

'When the boss is willing to accept those campaign dollars, it suggests a blind loyalty.'

CHRISTINE COLE, *Boston-based public safety consultant*

Workers bolster campaign account of indicted sheriff

Half of donations to Tompkins's committee came from employees

By Matt Stout and Danny McDonald

GLOBE STAFF

In his 12-plus years as Suffolk County sheriff, Steven W. Tompkins has wielded the weight of his office to get his opponent's campaign signs removed, land his niece a job, and, prosecutors now allege, extort a cannabis company.

The department has played another role, too: Its workers are integral to stocking Tompkins's campaign account.

Since starting his second full term in January 2023, Tompkins has relied heavily on donations from those who work for him, and then used huge chunks of what he raised to repay himself nearly \$45,000 in loans and cover a bill from a law firm that represented him in a past ethics probe. Outside of monthly payments to a campaign consultant, those accounted for the largest campaign expenses he reported. Current and former employees at the

Suffolk County Sheriff's Department, as well as their family members, have accounted for one of every two donations Tompkins has taken in that time frame, according to a Globe analysis of campaign finance data. All told, they've contributed nearly \$54,000 in that time, the Globe found — making up 51 percent of the cash Tompkins raised from donors.

Tompkins pulled in the donations during a relatively quiet time for campaigning, after his 2022 reelection and years before his seat is back on the ballot in 2028.

TOMPKINS, Page B5

Trump backs off cease-fire demand

Shifts to Putin's favored option: Kyiv ceding land

By Jim Tankersley, Steven Erlanger, and Steve Lohr

NEW YORK TIMES

BERLIN — After their summit in Alaska, President Trump sided on Saturday with President Vladimir Putin of Russia, adopting Putin's preference for pursuing a peace agreement based on Ukraine ceding unconquered territory to Russia instead of the urgent cease-fire Trump had said he wanted before the meeting.

The change could give Russia an advantage in talks to end the fighting, which are due to continue Monday when President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine visits the White House. It would also be a break from the strategy that Trump and European allies, as well as Zelensky, had agreed to before the US-Russia summit in Alaska, and it provoked a chilly reception in Europe, where leaders have time and again seen Trump reverse positions on Ukraine after speaking with Putin.

Trump wrote on social media early Saturday that he had spoken by phone to Zelensky and other European leaders after his meeting with

SUMMIT, Page A2

GOP leader's star wanes as successors bid

Some in Kentucky eager to look past McConnell

By Sam Brodey

GLOBE STAFF

SHEPHERDSVILLE, Ky. — There's a wide-open field of Republican candidates vying to be Kentucky's next senator — from seasoned politicians to entrepreneurs and outsiders — but increasingly, there's only one qualification for the job that really matters to GOP voters.

"They want someone separated from Mitch McConnell," said Allan Maricle, a longtime Kentucky Republican figure.

After 40 years in office, McConnell, the retiring Senate titan and hard-charging Republican partisan, has come to represent the Washington status quo to many back home. More recently, McConnell's sometimes sharp conflicts with President Trump — who now regularly denigrates the senator — have only increased the excitement among rank-and-file Republicans about the opportunity to replace him in the 2026 midterm elections.